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‘HOPE HAS A HOME’

Radical vision of the Obama Presidential Center: Rethinking what a presidential library can be



Above: A bust of the Rev. Martin Luther King Jr. displayed in a replica of the Oval Office at the Obama Presidential Center. **Top:** The Obama Presidential Center on June 3 ahead of its opening. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

TRIBUNE EDITORIAL: The editorial board says the Obama Presidential Center represents an unprecedented \$850 million investment in Chicago’s South Side, coming at a time when Chicago really can use the shot in the arm. **Opinion, Page B1**

By Christopher Borrelli
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Obama Presidential Center, which opens to the public on Friday, on Juneteenth, hugs the north end of Jackson Park, runs alongside a lagoon, rises 225 feet at its highest, and rolls backward down Stony Island Avenue, settling into 58,000 square feet of brilliantly green sloping lawn. Michelle Obama wants you to sled here in the winter. Nearby are picnic tables and a sprawling fruit and vegetable garden and cast-iron BBQ pits for grilling — Barack Obama would like you to use those in the summer. Need a book, and there’s a new branch of the Chicago Public Library, one of the center’s four buildings. Want to exercise, and there’s 60,000 square feet of athletic facilities, rooted around an NBA-regulation court, the Obama Foundation’s rising-sun at its hub.

Everything about the Obama Presidential Center feels inviting, packed with meaning, deliberate, more than you expect of what is ostensibly an \$850 million community center.

Or rather, a museum with a remarkable, warm-hearted community center attached. Initially, it can be hard to explain exactly how this place should be described. But on your first or second visit, do not expect to dip in and dip out. This is an all-day place.

ObamaLand.

That is not meant glibly, but literally: the Obama Presidential Center is a world unto itself, a self-contained universe, a self-described space where “hope has a home,” where every cynical thought you bring in is met with a history lesson and call to action, where the former president is like the Mickey Mouse, steadfast optimist,

See **OBAMA** on Page A12

FEMA denials raise scrutiny

Illinois has struggled to secure federal disaster relief under Trump

By Daniel C. Vock
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Flooding on Chicago’s Southwest Side is nothing new, but Ald. Marty Quinn was shocked by the damage last July’s storms caused.

The July 25 deluge dumped 3.25 inches of rain on Midway Airport in one day, with some areas of the city receiving 5 to 6 inches. The down-pour quickly overwhelmed the city’s sewer system, and even the regional network of deep tunnels and reservoirs couldn’t keep up.

“All along 59th Street, the power of the water was popping off manhole covers in the middle of the street,” the 13th Wawrd alderman said. The flooding even dislodged two sewer covers over deep shafts that were so big it took a city crew with a backhoe to reset them. “I’ve never seen anything like it.”

More than 4,200 Chicago residents called 311 to report basement floods. When the sewers filled, water mixed with raw sewage and the toxic mixture backed up into people’s homes, destroying floors, walls and appliances and leaving behind mold, foundation damage and destroyed vehicles. Many had to leave their homes or stay home from work. Most lacked insurance to cover the costs, officials later said.

The storms hit the south suburbs and broader Illinois hard, too, with state officials tallying nearly 5,000 structures affected. The state of Illinois put the average household damage at \$16,784 and asked Washington for federal disaster relief.

But President Donald Trump said no.

In fact, on the same day, Trump said no twice, denying Illinois’ request for the July storms and rejecting a second request for

See **DENIALS** on Page A2

INSIDE

Trump says peace deal with Iran is at hand

President Donald Trump said the United States and Iran would sign a peace deal Sunday, though Iran said the timeline could be slower. **Nation & World, Page B5**

The real Ferris Bueller?

For the film’s 40th anniversary, we found the man who most likely inspired the iconic character. **Arts & Entertainment**



Rollback of coal ash rules sparks outrage

Environmentalists find EPA’s proposed changes worrisome for those living along the Great Lakes

By Christiana Freitag
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

TOWN OF PINES, Ind. — In the herb garden beside her home on Colorado Avenue, Cathi Murray digs through the soil and pulls out two glittering black rocks.

They’re not ordinary stones, she said. They’re pieces of coal ash — waste from coal burned at the nearby Michigan City Generating Station, less than 3 miles away on the southern shores of Lake Michigan.

The rocks and dust she finds in

her backyard and along the overgrown right of way behind her home — places where her two daughters played growing up — are a constant reminder of the contamination that has shaped life for the three decades Murray and her family have lived in Town of Pines, simply called Pines by residents.

“It’s everywhere,” Murray said.

Beginning in the late 1970s, the plant’s owner, Northern Indiana Public Service Co., distributed excess coal ash, which contains heavy metals and other pollutants, throughout the community as fill

material for roads, landscaping projects and residential properties, according to the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency. Exposure to those substances has been linked to cancers, neurological disorders and other health problems, the National Institute of Health says.

Until the 1990s, the power company disposed of over 1 million tons of coal ash in an unlined storage area in Pines, later contaminating the groundwater that supplied the town of 700. More than 20 years after being declared a Superfund site, Pines is still struggling with pollution.

“Once you make a mess, it takes

See **RULES** on Page A10



Ashley Williams, executive director of Just Transition Northwest Indiana, stands in Pullman Park in Michigan City, Indiana, on May 21.

Williams moved to Michigan City in part to close NIPSCO’s Michigan City Generating Station, seen behind her. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H:70 L: 54
MON. H:75 L: 58
TUE. H:77 L: 57
Complete details on Page A20

INDEX

Almanac A17
Crossword ... In Comics
Editorials B1
Horoscope ... In Comics
Letters B3
Obituaries A18
Rides G7
Success G4
Television E6

179th year No. 165
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